Website migration checklist

Move a site without losing rankings: tasks for before the move, launch day and the 8–12 weeks after, a hosting-only list, a 301 redirect map and a weekly tracker.

How to use this checklist

1. **Describe the migration** on the card below. The type of move decides which items apply to you. Hosting change only: the “New server only” box below part C plus the baseline, testing and monitoring is enough.
2. **Assign owners and due dates** to every task. Tasks without an owner are the ones that get skipped.
3. **Collect URLs and a baseline** from Search Console and GA4 before you change anything. Note the export date.
4. **Fill in the redirect map** (part D): one old URL = one destination URL, a 301 code and a priority.
5. **On launch day**, work through part B in order and record each test result.
6. **For the first 4 weeks**, crawl the site and review errors daily; until week 12, update the tracker (part E) once a week. Add every new 404 to the map.

Migration card

Type of migration	☐ new domain ☐ new subdomain ☐ new URLs / CMS ☐ HTTP → HTTPS ☐ new server or hosting ☐ redesign		
Old domain		**New domain**	
Staging URL		**Launch date and time**	
SEO owner		**Developer**	
Content owner		**Data export date**	

The Search Console Change of Address tool applies only to moves to a different domain or subdomain; submit it for every variant of the old domain (www, non-www, subdomains). For HTTP → HTTPS, www ↔ non-www and path changes on the same domain, redirects and a new sitemap are enough.

A. Before the move

	Task	Owner	Due
☐	Complete list of old URLs: sitemaps, server logs, analytics, CMS, Search Console Links report, full site crawl		
☐	Images, videos, PDFs, JavaScript and CSS files added to the list		
☐	Search Console export: pages and queries with the most clicks (Performance), number of indexed pages (Pages)		
☐	GA4 baseline: organic traffic and key events (enter in part E)		
☐	List of 20–50 priority URLs to test on launch day		
☐	List of sites linking to old URLs		
☐	Redirect map (part D): every old URL to its closest match, a 301, no redirects to the home page		
☐	Content with no equivalent set to return 404 or 410		
☐	Staging protected by password, IP restriction or noindex (not Disallow alone); note of what to remove at launch		
☐	Full staging crawl: status codes, noindex, canonical tags, links		
☐	Self-referencing canonical tags on new URLs		

	Task	Owner	Due
☐	hreflang points to the new URLs, reciprocally across all language versions (x-default for unmatched languages)		
☐	Internal links (menu, footer, body copy) changed to the new URLs, no redirects in between		
☐	Structured data, title tags and meta descriptions carried over		
☐	GA4 and Google Tag Manager set up, key events tested on staging		
☐	New XML sitemap with final destination URLs only; old sitemap kept for monitoring		
☐	Old and new sites verified in Search Console in every variant (www and non-www, HTTP and HTTPS); verification file or meta tag on the new site; disavow file uploaded		
☐	Purchased domain: no manual actions or URL removal requests left by the previous owner		
☐	Server has headroom, because Google crawls more heavily than usual after launch; for a large site, hosting provider warned		
☐	Speed of the new version measured on staging (Lighthouse) and compared with the old one; forms work		
☐	Launch outside peak season; developer available for the whole launch day		

B. Launch day (in this order)

	Task	Owner	Time
☐	Redirects from the map deployed before the old version stops responding		
☐	Staging blocks removed: noindex, password, unneeded Disallow rules (WordPress: Settings → Reading, “Discourage search engines from indexing this site”)		
☐	robots.txt on the new site blocks only what should stay hidden; rules for Googlebot, Bingbot and AI crawlers (e.g. OAI-SearchBot) same as on the old site		
☐	Canonical tags point to the new URLs (not staging, not the old domain)		
☐	Priority URLs tested: status code, redirect target, title, content, forms (e.g. URL Inspection tool)		
☐	New sitemap submitted in Search Console and listed in robots.txt (old one stays in Search Console for a few weeks)		
☐	Change of Address tool submitted after redirects are live, for every variant of the old domain (new domain or subdomain only; one Google account with owner access to both properties)		
☐	Bing Webmaster Tools: new site added, new sitemap submitted		
☐	GA4 collecting page views, key events (forms, calls) recorded		

C. After the move (8–12 weeks)

	When	Task	Owner
☐	Within 48 h	Comparison crawl of the live site against the staging crawl	
☐	Weeks 1–4	Daily crawl of the new site, review of 404s and the Pages report, missing URLs added to the map	
☐	Weeks 1–2	Redirect chains collapsed to a single hop	

	When	Task	Owner
☐	Weeks 1–2	Remaining internal links point to final URLs, not redirects	
☐	Weeks 2–4	Most valuable backlinks updated by the linking sites	
☐	Weeks 1–4	New URL in Google Business Profile, social profiles and ad campaigns	
☐	Every week	Clicks, impressions and priority query positions compared with the baseline (part E); server logs or the Crawl stats report	
☐	Every month	AI answers: Google AI Overviews, ChatGPT and Perplexity still name the business for key questions	
☐	1 year min.	Redirects and old domain registration kept (Google recommends at least a year)	

New server or hosting only (same URLs)

☐	DNS record TTL lowered at least a week before the move (for example to a few hours)
☐	Copy on the new server tested before the DNS change: pages, images, forms, downloads
☐	Firewall and DoS protection don’t block Googlebot (check with the URL Inspection tool)
☐	Search Console verification works on the new server (HTML file or meta tag)
☐	Build-time blocks (noindex, Disallow) removed before the DNS records change
☐	Old hosting shut down only once it gets no traffic, Googlebot included

You don’t need redirects or the Change of Address tool. Do the baseline, priority URL tests and monitoring (parts A, B and E) the same way.

D. Redirect map

Rules

- **One hop:** each old URL goes straight to its final destination, with no chains.
- **301 or 308** (permanent), not 302 or 307. Server-side redirects, not JavaScript.
- **Closest match** in content, not the home page. Pages merged into one can all point to it. No equivalent = 404 or 410.
- **One URL format:** HTTPS, trailing slash or not, lowercase, www or non-www.

#	Old URL	New URL	Code	Priority	Test (date, result)
e.g.	*/services/web-design.html*	*/web-design/*	*301*	*High*	*12 Jan · OK*
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					
10					
11					
12					
13					
14					
15					
16					
17					
18					
19					
20					

Priority: high = URL with Google traffic or backlinks; medium = URL in the site structure; low = everything else. For a larger site, keep the map in a spreadsheet with the same columns.

E. Weekly tracker

Week	Date	Google clicks	Impressions	404 errors	Indexed: new / old sitemap	Notes
Baseline						
Week 1						
Week 2						
Week 3						
Week 4						
Week 5						
Week 6						
Week 7						
Week 8						
Week 9						
Week 10						
Week 11						
Week 12						

Ranking movement in the first weeks is normal: according to Google, a medium-sized site can take a few weeks or more before the new URLs replace the old ones. Watch for a drop that sticks or a growing number of 404s. Indexed URLs from the new sitemap should rise while the old sitemap's count falls.

F. Post-migration issue log

Date	Issue (URL, symptom)	Cause	Fix	Owner	Done
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐

www.ai-seo-company.pl/en/tools/website-migration-checklist

Sources (accessed November 11, 2026): Google Search Central "How to move a site", "Changing your hosting", "Redirects and Google Search", "Introduction to robots.txt"; Search Console Help "Change of Address tool".

AI SIGNALS COMPANY P.S.A., ul. Grzybowska 12/14 lok. B-3, 00-132 Warszawa